HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Food for the Soul: Yishak's Meal and the Prophetic Blessing

Given Monday 9 November 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem 10.4

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam), Chapter 10, p. 210

Chapter: Perek Yud (10) — **Perishut**, abstinence

Topic: Parashat Toldot. Why did Yitzchak ask for a meal before giving his blessing, and why are the blessings themselves so physical? Rabbeinu Avraham's answer: the meal was **food for the soul**, to revive Yitzchak for a **prophetic blessing**, and the material blessings are a means to spiritual greatness, not the goal.

When: Rosh Chodesh Kislev 5787. Monday, 6:00–7:00pm on Zoom.

Schedule note: Tonight the whole shiur is on the parashah, because Rabbeinu Avraham's discussion falls exactly on Toldot. Next week we go back to the section we skipped: **fasting**.

Where We Are in Chapter 10

Perishut is an important trait. The prophets and the righteous chose simple jobs. These didn't make them rich, but left them free to serve Hashem.

Perishut is in the heart. It does not mean constantly abstaining. It means thinking less about the things you do without. A wealthy person can be a true *parush*, because these things are not on his mind. A poor person may not be, because they are always on his mind.

How to reach it (last week):

1. **Understand it intellectually.** Food, drink, clothes and mansions are not who we are. We share them with animals, and they last a short time. Anyone with *מוח בקדקדו* knows this.
2. **Bring it down to the heart.** *וידעת היום* is the first step. *והשבות אל לבבך* is the harder one.
3. **Break the habit, slowly.** Assess where you are and make a plan: if you have five dishes, have four for a while. Going too fast causes physical, emotional and spiritual problems.

What we are skipping (and will return to)

The Rabbi doesn't like to skip, because an author orders his book for a reason. But for the parashah he gave a one-minute preview:

- **Fasting** as training for perishut, and the apparent contradiction with the Rambam in the Eight Chapters, who wrote strongly against people who cut themselves off and don't eat.
- **Obstacles:** the more people depend on you, the harder perishut becomes.
- **The sign you have reached it:** you are not moved by gaining or losing material things.
- **The benefits** of perishut, mental and spiritual.

Rabbeinu Avraham then raises **three questions** against perishut:

	The question	When
1	The Torah's blessings all seem physical	In a couple of weeks
2	The story of Yitzchak's blessings	**Tonight**
3	The garments of the Kohanim	Later

Part One — The Story (Bereishit 27)

The Rabbi first read the verses, asking us to notice a few details.

Yitzchak to Esav: *הנה נא זקנתי לא ידעתי יום מותי.* "I have grown old; I don't know the day of my death." Take your gear and hunt for me.

ועשה לי מטעמים כאשר אהבתי והביאה לי ואכלה בעבור תברכך נפשי בטרם אמות.

"Make me tasty food as I love, and I will eat, **so that my soul may bless you** before I die."

Rivka repeats it to Yaakov: *הביאה לי ציד ועשה לי מטעמים ואכלה ואברכה לפני ה' לפני מותי.* She says **"and I will bless you."** She does not say "my soul."

Yaakov to Yitzchak: בעבור תברכני נפשך *קום נא שבה ואכלה מצידי***.** "So that **your soul** may bless me."

Yaakov brings wine: *ויבא לו יין וישת.* Yitzchak never asked for wine.

The blessing: *ויתן לך האלקים מטל השמים ומשמני הארץ ורב דגן ותירש. יעבדוך עמים... הוה גביר לאחיך... ארריך ארור ומברכיך ברוך.* First produce, then power, then "those who bless you are blessed."

Yitzchak to Esav afterwards: *הן גביר שמתיו לך... ודגן ותירש סמכתיו.* Now he puts **the mastery first** and the produce second.

Part Two — The Two Questions

One of the strong questions against perishut is the **עוד אחד מן הקושיות החזקות כנגד הפרישות.** story of Yitzchak's blessing. It comes from two sides.

Question 1: the meal. Yitzchak ties his blessing to tasty food, and Yaakov adds wine. *איזו חיבה להנאת העולם גדולה מחיבה זו?* What greater attachment to worldly pleasure could there be?

Question 2: the blessing. The blessing itself is entirely physical: dew, fat of the land, grain, wine, nations bowing. *כל הדברים האלו בעלי טבע גשמי הם.*

Part Three — The Meal Was Food for the Soul

Three preliminaries

1. The soul depends on the body

Our real identity is the soul, our mind and intellect. That is **נשמת האדם היא הקשר בינו ובין בוראו.** where the prophet receives prophecy.

But as long as a person is alive, the soul is **entangled with the body**. *ובהחלש הגוף תחלשנה מחשבותיו.* When the body weakens, so do the thoughts.

"We feel this. When you're ill, it's hard to think. It's hard to develop spiritually."

2. Prophecy needs joy and strength

אין הנבואה שורה לא מתוך עצבות ולא מתוך עצלות אלא מתוך שמחה.

You cannot prophesy when you are sad, lethargic or ill. You need to be awake, full of energy and hope. So the prophets kept instruments by them, *נבל ותוף וחליל וכינור*. Elisha asked for a musician: *ועתה קחו לי מנגן*.

"This is why we have a duty to look after our bodies, to exercise and look after our health. When your body is strong, you can develop yourself spiritually much better."

Rabbeinu Avraham notes that his father wrote this in three places: the **Eight Chapters** (ch. 7), the **Mishneh Torah** (Yesodei HaTorah), and the **Moreh**. We have learned the first two together.

3. Yitzchak was weak, and this was a prophetic blessing

On the simple level, the dim eyes explain how Yaakov could take *ויהי כי זקן יצחק ותכהין עיניו מראות*. the blessing. On a deeper level, says Rabbeinu Avraham, **the eyes show the state of the whole body**.

Yitzchak did not want an ordinary blessing, *כדרך שמברכים בני אדם איש את רעהו*. He wanted to bless **מתוך שפע נבואי**, from prophetic inspiration. Even Bil'am could only say *את אשר ישים ה' בפי*; all the more so Yitzchak.

How do we know it was prophetic? When Yitzchak discovered what had happened, *ויחרד יצחק חרדה גדלה עד מאד*. Yet he did not retract. He said: **גם ברוך יהיה**.

"If your child deceived you and took the wrong thing, you'd say: I take it back. He didn't." Yitzchak knew the blessing came from Hashem. If it reached Yaakov, Yaakov was meant to have it.

The answer

Yitzchak did not ask for the meal **לספק תאותו**, to satisfy a craving, nor as a bribe for the blessing. He asked for it **להשיב את מזגו ולשמח נפשו**: to restore his strength and gladden his soul, so that he could bless prophetically.

That is why he said **בעבור תברכך נפשי**, "so that **my soul** may bless you."

Rabbeinu Avraham adds, as his own suggestion, that Yitzchak may have felt a sudden decline. He says twice, *לא ידעתי יום מותי* and *בטרם אמות*. *"It happens with the elderly: a ninety-year-old goes into hospital and a week later he's gone."*

Part Four — Who Understood "My Soul"?

The verses show three different people hearing the same instruction.

	What they heard	What they understood
Rivka	Heard Yitzchak say *תברכך נפשי*	Repeated only *ואברככה*. She did not stress the prophetic point
Esav	Heard it from Yitzchak directly	Understood it once he heard it, and said *בעבור תברכני נפשך*
Yaakov	Never heard it. Rivka left it out	**Worked it out himself**, and said *בעבור תברכני נפשך*

Yaakov's insight: why would my father ask for game and tasty food now? He must be preparing for a prophetic blessing. So Yaakov said "**your soul**", and on his own initiative **brought wine**. *ויין ישמח לבב אנוש* (fitting for Rosh Chodesh).

Not to drunkenness: *אל תחשוב שהוא חס ושלום שתה משקה משכחת השכל.* Just enough to lift the spirit. *"The difference between one shot of whiskey and five."*

About Rivka: Rabbeinu Avraham is careful. He does not mean she missed the importance of the blessing, only that she did not dwell on the exact wording. Possibly she just shortened it. *"Not every prophet understands everything all the time."*

A side point: Esav was not simply wicked

כי אף שלא הגיע למעלת שלמותו של יעקב, היתה לו גם כן שלמות.

Rabbeinu Avraham says plainly that **Esav had a real level of perfection**, though less than Yaakov's. The proofs: Yitzchak thought him worthy of the prophetic blessing, and Esav longed for the blessing and grieved when he lost it.

The Rabbi recalled **Rabbi Jacobs z"l** of Neve Shalom in Wembley, the scholar of Midrash, who explained this to him many times. **Midrash teaches in black and white.** To educate clearly, especially beginners and children, it contrasts the very righteous with the less righteous. So children come home with *Yaakov HaTzaddik* and *Esav HaRasha*.

"We need to get out of this idea that Esav was this wicked person."

Why ask Esav to fetch it?

Why not prepare the food himself, or ask Rivka? Two answers:

1. **Rabbi Avraham HeChasid** (a friend of the author): to create a closeness between Yitzchak and the son he was about to bless.
2. **Rabbeinu Avraham:** fresh game simply suited Yitzchak better and would revive him more.

Part Five — Why the Blessings Are Physical

Material blessing is the means

Rabbeinu Avraham returns to his father's teaching in **Hilchot Teshuvah**: the Torah's material rewards are there so that a person is **free** to serve Hashem and grow, not as the reward itself.

So read the blessing in order:

Step	The words	What it means
1. The means	*מטל השמים ומשמני הארץ ורב דגן ותירש*	Plenty, so you are free from worry
2. The result	*יעבדוך עמים... הוה גביר לאחיך*	You grow until you stand out spiritually, and people look up to you
3. The Shechinah	*ארריך ארור ומברכיך ברוך*	The Shechinah rests on you, so whoever is with you is blessed

"You've always read these blessings wrong. Not: you'll have money, so people will bow to you because of your power. You'll have parnassah, so you'll be free to work on yourself, and people will see you're on a different level."

Compare Ki Tavo: **וראו כל עמי הארץ כי שם ה' נקרא עליך ויראו ממך.**

The same blessing as Bil'am's

Bil'am's final blessing came with *ותהי עליו רוח אלקים*.

מה טבו אהליך יעקב משכנתיך ישראל.

אהליך יעקב — (*tzniut*) your physical homes, set so no one looked into another's.

משכנתיך ישראל — Bil'am is addressing **Hashem**: *Your* dwelling places among Israel, the Mishkan and the Mikdash. *ושכנתי בתוכם*.

A few verses later Bil'am says **מברכיך ברוך וארריך ארור**. Because the Shechinah dwells among Israel, those who bless them are blessed.

Yitzchak said the same thing, briefly. *ברכת יצחק נאמרה בקיצור, ברכת בלעם בהרחבה.*

What about the Midrash on the order?

Yitzchak puts the blessing first; Bil'am puts the curse first. A well-known derash says each showed what he really wanted.

Rabbeinu Avraham says not to be troubled. Such derashot are meant **for the general public**. On the plain level it is the same blessing, and the order makes no difference.

The blessing is that you can keep the mitzvot

Yitzchak spelled out the physical goods, just as the Torah spells out the physical rewards, and **hinted** at the spiritual ones.

את הברכה אשר תשמעו אל מצות ה' אלקיכם. (Re'eh)

"I've read this verse so many times and never noticed." The blessing **is** that you listen to Hashem's mitzvot. That is the greatest blessing. And how can you do it? When you have what you need.

The proof: הן גביר שמתיו לך

When Yitzchak tells Esav what he gave Yaakov, he reverses the order:

הן גביר שמתיו לך... ודגן ותירש סמכתיו.

The **main** blessing was the greatness, so he says it first. The produce is only *סמכתיו*, "I supported him": a means and a help, **not the goal**.

Esav's blessing

Esav was blessed **only with this world**: *הנה משמני הארץ יהיה מושבך... ועל חרבך תחיה ואת אחיך תעבד.*

Will he always serve? Only while Yaakov's descendants keep the Torah. Onkelos: *כד יעברון בנוהי על פתגמי אורייתא*. When they stray from it, Esav's fear of them leaves him, though even then he does not reach Yaakov's greatness.

Summary

Question 1: why did Yitzchak ask for a meal? He was old and weak, his eyes were dim, and he may have felt death near. Prophecy needs a strong body and joy. The meal, and Yaakov's wine, were to revive him for a **prophetic blessing**: *בעבור תברכך נפשי*.

Who understood: Yaakov worked it out alone. Esav understood once he heard it. Rivka did not pass it on. Esav had real *shleimut*, less than Yaakov's.

Question 2: why are the blessings physical? Material plenty frees a person to grow. That growth makes him distinguished, the Shechinah rests on him, and so *מברכיך ברוך*, as in Bil'am's blessing. The proof is *הן גביר שמתיו לך... ודגן ותירש סמכתיו*: greatness is the goal, the produce only the support.

"Plenty to share on the Shabbos table this week. Listen to it again before Shabbos."

Coming Up

Next week: back to perishut. Fasting as training, the apparent contradiction with the Rambam in the Eight Chapters, the obstacles, the signs, and the benefits.

Tomorrow evening: the Moreh Nebuchim shiur continues as usual.

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